

Figure 9.30 Chambarumal Embroidery

9.5.3 Kantha Embroidery

Region

Kantha is an embroidery technique that originated in West Bengal. In the past, it was used to convert old used fabric into an embroidered textile.

Technique

The embroidery is executed on layers of old white cotton saris. Layers of cotton saris are stitched together with simple running stitch in white thread. The motifs are traced and embroidered using different coloured threads also. The embroidery threads used are drawn from the old sari borders. The basic stitch used is running stitch along with satin stitch and chain stitch

Motifs

The motifs used in Kantha are lotus flowers, floral scrolls, tree of life, mandala, foliages, creepers, animal and bird forms; fish, sunrise, mermaids, ships, submarine scenes; domestic articles like mirrors, pitcher, nutcracker, umbrella, musical instruments and human figures like gods and goddesses, horseman, fisherwoman etc. The designs of folk stories, epics, mythological background, ritualistic motifs, animals, dancing peacock, temples, are also different types of costumes.

Lotus is the most common and important motif widely used in Kantha . 'Kalka' is another important motif a cone mango shaped.

Style of Embroidery

Different embroidery layouts are followed in Kantha. Some examples are; central motif and tree of life on all four corners, arrangement of motifs in panels or a big central panel and placement of smaller motifs all over the textiles



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